ORIGIN OF CRICKET - IN INDIA

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Introduction

The origin of cricket is unknown as there are many beliefs regarding the etymology of the word. Some people believe it to be originated from a French word 'Crequet[1]', meaning a Club while others think it to be derived from an English word 'Crycc'. , which means "stick," and, in its rude form, resembled the 13th century game known as club-ball. Cricket evolved in England in the 18th century, mainly because of the interest of great landowners who tried their skills on a field of play with their tenants and the local peasantry. Records show that teams from Kent and London played with each other in 1719, and that Kent and Sussex met in 1728.

Origin in India

The entire history of cricket in India and the sub-continent as a whole is based on the existence and development of the British Raj via East India Company.On 31 December 1600, Queen Elizabeth granted a Royal Charter to the East India Company[2]. Which was initially a joint-stock company that sought trading privileges in India and the East Indies? But the Royal Charter effectively gave it a 21-year monopoly on all trade in the region. In time, the East India Company transformed from a commercial trading venture to one which virtually ruled India as it acquired auxiliary governmental and military functions, until its dissolution in 1858 following the Indian revolt of 1857. The East India Company was the means by which cricket was introduced into India. In 1639, the Company effectively founded the city of Madras, and in 1661 acquired Portuguese territory on the west coast of India that included Bombay. In 1690, an Anglo- Mughal treaty allowed English merchants to establish a trading settlement on the Hooghly River, which subsequently became Calcutta. All of these places became major cricket centres as the popularity of the game grew among the native population. This is the earliest recorded reference to cricket in India. As the merchants metamorphosed into rulers, they continued to demonstrate their recreational pursuits on Indian soil. The British army took on the English settlers in what was the first recorded cricket match in India in 1751.The first definite reference to cricket being played anywhere in the sub-continent is a report of English sailors of

the East India Company written in 1737. .. There are no certain theories about the origin of Cricket in India but as British ruled on India for over 200 years, the game can be called as their legacy. The records show that the first ever cricket match in India was played in 1721 AD. . It says cricket being played at Cambay, near Vadodara[3.] Initially accepted by the Parsi community, this game of foreigners began to appear in organized form with the establishment of the 'Oriental Cricket Club' in 1848. It refers to cricket being played at Cambay, near Baroda in 1721. The establishment of the Calcutta Cricket Club (what we know today as CC & FC) in 1792, was another watershed for the sport in the land. In fact, it is the second-oldest cricket club in the world, after the MCC (1787).Ten years after its inception, the CCC organized a match between its team and the Old Etonians. The highlight of the game was Old Estonians Robert Vansittart's hundred. It was the first 'recorded' century on Indian soil. That game was watched by the locals, as were other encounters that took place elsewhere. It was but natural that the locals sought to copy what the 'rulers' were doing. Recent evidence suggests that members of the Indian army were among the first to take to the sport. The 'sepoys' of regiments based in Sylhet (now part of Bangladesh) were reported by a periodical of the time as being more energetic and cheerful cricketers than their European superiors. The latter did not mind this, and were in fact happy to engage in matches against their subordinates. In 1799, another club was formed at Seringapatam in south India after the successful British siege and the defeat of Tipu Sultan.

Other experts are of the opinion that the history of Indian Cricket started its journey in the place named Sylhet (currently in Bangladesh). Proper evidence has been found to prove this from the Sporting Intelligence magazine, on 3rd March, 1845. The report was published by the editor of the Englishman newspaper and the news item was titled as "Sepoy Cricketers". The reporter made proper observation of the match played between the European cricketers and the Sepoy cricketers. Apart from this news item, another report has been found to support the fact that Cricket was first played in Sylhet in India. This report was titled as "Sepoy Cricket at Sylhet" and in this report, the reporter mentioned about the match between two regimental sides, each of which contained at least eight native cricketers.

After its initiation, Cricket started to get popularity among the Indian people within a short period of time. The middle and last half of the nineteenth century was an important period in the history of Indian Cricket, as the game spread its reach in almost all the parts of India during that period. Many teams from England started touring India by the close of the nineteenth century. There is a report published in the newspaper, The Times of India, that supports this fact and the report was about the Presidency matches between the Parsees and the Lord Hawke's Englishmen. The match was held in Bombay in 1892. The report described how the international Cricket matches that took place in Bombay at that time, increased interest among the local people. The most important fixture in the 19th century was the Bombay Presidency Match which evolved, first, into the Bombay Triangular and then into the Bombay Quadrangular. The match was first played in 1877 and then intermittently for several seasons until finally being given first-class status in 1892-93.

. First-class cricket definitely began in the 1892–93 season with two Europeans v/s Parsees matches, at Bombay In the same season, Lord Hawke captained an

English team that played four first-class matches including a game against "All India" on 26–28 January 1893. Undoubtedly, from this point, the journey of Indian cricket began. The Parsees were followed by the Hindus, who formed the Hindu Gymkhana in 1866. The scene of the cricketing activities of the Parses' was the first Indian civilian community to cricket. They set up the Oriental Cricket Club in Mumbai in at Esplanade 'maidan,' which was situated in front of the western ramparts of the erstwhile Bombay 'Fort' (demolished in 1860). At the far end of this 'maidan' was a plot of land that was out of bounds for dogs and Indians - the Bombay Gymkhana. Cricket was also gaining in popularity in other cities at around the same time. 1884 was an eventful year, in that a team from Sri Lanka played a match in Kolkata. It was the country's first shot at international cricket. The Parsi Gymkhana was set up in Mumbai in the same year. A year later, Kolkata hosted a match between the Presidency Club and a team from Australia. The relative economic stability of the Parsis was instrumental in their sending a team on a tour of England in 1886. Dr. D.H. Patel, one of the leading cricketers of the time, was named captain. At the team's send-off in Bombay, Pherozeshah Mehta, one of the eminent Indians of the time, stated the squad's objective; "As artists go to Italy to do homage to the Great Masters, or as pilgrims go to Jerusalem to worship at a shrine, so now the Paresis are going to England to pay homage to the English cricketers, to learn something of that noble and manly pastime in the very country that is cricket's chosen home."As was expected, the Parsis could not get the better of their seasoned opponents, but they gained a lot of experience. The second Parsi outfit that went to England in 1888 was far more confident than its predecessor. The visitors exceeded all expectations, winning eight matches, losing eleven, and drawing twelve. The British sent a team to India in 1889-90 under the captaincy of G.F. Vernon. The main aim of the team was to play against Englishmen living in India. Critically from the Indian point of view, one game was scheduled against the Parsis, in the light of their impressive showing in 1888. In what was a red-letter event for Indian cricket, the Parsis prevailed by four wickets. It was the first cricket defeat suffered by the British on Indian soil, and indeed, their first 'defeat' of any kind since they had crushed the War of Independence in 1857. However, while they were unremitting on the political front, the British were supportive on the sporting one. Lord Hawke's team that toured India in 1892-93 made room for two matches against the Parsis, wherein the spoils were shared. Harris, one of the game's influential figures of the time, did his bit in his capacity as Governor of the Bombay Province to further Indian interest in cricket. He instituted an annual 'Presidency' match between the Europeans and the Parsis, and also earmarked land on the Mumbai seafront, for the Parsis, Hindus and Muslims to set up their respective 'Gymkhanas' and 'maidans.' The game had by then spread across the subcontinent. It gained a fillip in the 1890s when the Prince of the state of Nawanagar wowed all those in England who thronged to watch him bat. Kumar Shri Ranjitsinh ji was elegance personified on the cricket field. His fascinating wristwork and unconventional shot-making skills were a revelation to the British, who were born and bred on an orthodox approach. His success, first for Sussex in the English County Championship, and then England in Test cricket, made him one of the most popular personalities in the Empire 'where the sun never set.

His fellow Princes were quick on the uptake. Some of them took it upon themselves to do their bit for cricket, to facilitate their entry into the 'good books' of the British rulers. The 'princely' influence worked wonders for cricket in India, as did other parallel developments. 1911 witnessed the first-ever tour of England by an 'All-India' team. Sponsored and captained by the Maharaja of Patiala, the team featured the best cricketers of the time. The top performer was the

left-arm spinner Baloo Palwankar, who bagged over a hundred wickets. It was a memorable performance in more ways than one. A member of the so-called 'untouchable' segment of the Hindu society, Baloo underwent many a reverse early in his life. However, merit eventually superseded all the other factors, and Baloo went on to become the premier member of the Hindu side. He also captained them for a number of years in the annual Quadrangular.

The outbreak of World War I prevented visits by cricket teams from England to India in the 1910s. It was in 1926, eight years after the end of the War, that two representatives of the Calcutta Cricket Club travelled to London to attend a couple of meetings of the Imperial Cricket Conference.(Now is known as International Cricket council) Technically, the CCC should not have been allowed to participate in the meeting, as the club did not have exclusive control over cricket in India. But the club had the blessings of Lord Harris, who was Chairman of the ICC at the time. A significant outcome of the meeting was the MCC's decision to send a team to India in 1926-27. Arthur Gilligan, who had captained England in the 1924-25 Ashes, was assigned the captaincy of the team. The match between the visitors and the Hindus at the Bombay Gymkhana was made memorable by the man who had hit a six on his first-class debut in 1916.

By then, not only was cricket being played all over the subcontinent by the locals, but it had also scaled unforeseen heights of popularity. An annual Presidency match between the Europeans and Indians had been instituted in Chennai in 1915. It was played during the Pongal festivities. Sind, Calcutta, Lahore, Lucknow, Hyderabad and Kanpur were among the other leading cricket centres on the subcontinent. The Maharaja of Patiala supervised the creation of cricket arenas in Patiala and Chail, where he arranged for coaches from overseas to train junior cricketers.

Gilligan was one of the active participants in a meeting in Delhi in February 1927. The Maharaja of Patiala, a British businessman named Grant Govan, and Anthony De Mello were the other attendees. Gilligan expressed his praise of Indian cricket, and promised to press for India's inclusion in the ICC, if all the promoters of cricket in the land came together to establish a single controlling body.

Govan, Patiala and De Mello in turn assured Gilligan that they would do their bit. They convened a meeting in Delhi on 21st November 1927,which was attended by around forty-five delegates. These comprised cricket representatives from Sind, Punjab, Patiala, Delhi, the United Provinces, Rajputana, Alwar, Bhopal, Gwalior, Baroda, Kathiawar and Central India. There was a consensus that a Board of Cricket Control was essential to ensure the following:

- Advance and control the game of cricket throughout India
- Arrange and control inter-territorial, foreign and other cricket matches.
- Make arrangements incidental to visits of teams to India, and to manage and control All-India representatives playing within and outside India.
- If necessary, to control and arrange all or any inter-territorial disputes.
- To settle disputes or differences between Associations affiliated to the Board and appeals referred to it by any such Associations.
- To adopt if desirable, all rules or amendments passed by the Marylebone Cricket Club.

Another meeting, held at the Bombay Gymkhana on 10th December 1927, ended with a unanimous decision to form a 'Provisional' Board of Control to represent cricket in India. The plan was for this 'Provisional' Board to cease to function as soon as eight territorial cricket associations were created. Representatives of the eight associations would then come together to constitute the Board.

Govan and De Mello visited England in 1928, where they made out a case on India's behalf in front of the ICC. Their deliberations were satisfactory, but it turned out that their efforts had not been complemented in their absence. In late 1928, only six associations - Southern Punjab Cricket Association, Cricket Association of Bengal, Assam Cricket Association, Madras Cricket Association and Northern India Cricket Association - had been formed.

The Provisional Board met in Mumbai in December 1928 during the Quadrangular tournament, to discuss the next course of action. It was at this meeting that Govan and De Mello prevailed upon the others to reconsider the decision taken at the previous year's meeting. They did not want India to miss out on the opportunity to host South Africa in 1929 and tour England in 1931!

Their persistence paid off. The Provisional Board was deemed to have finished its work, and the Board of Control for Cricket in India established. Govan was the first President, and De Mello the first Secretary[5]. Five months later, the ICC admitted India as a Full Member. India had to wait till 1932 to become a Test-playing natioion[4].

Cricket was played as a sport by the first half of the twentieth century. As the Hindus of India too started playing the game, the tournament of Bombay Presidency Matches became the Bombay Triangular in 1907-08. In 1912-13, the entry of the Muslims made it a quadrangular.

The First Test Match was played in 1932. Though India did not have a national cricket team during the early 1900s, a few Indian great cricketers of that era did represent the England cricket team. Maharaja Ranjit Singh and Duleep Singh ji were the prominent ones among them. However, the first international exposure in the history of Indian Cricket came in the year 1926. In that year, a team from the Marylebone Cricket Club (MCC), led by A.E.R Gilligan toured India. Though it was an unofficial tour, the Indian people were quite interested and enthusiastic about the matches that MCC played during the tour. The legendary Indian cricket player, C. K. Nayudu played brilliantly during that tour and he also scored a century against the MCC side in Bombay. The tour was responsible to redefine the contours of Indian cricket. It ultimately spearheaded to the formation of the Board of Control for Cricket in India (BCCI) in the year 1928. India was accredited Test status by 1932, much before it got its Independence in 1947. India played against England in that year.

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